Ukrainian Refugees in the EU

Economic Reality vs Public Perception

Data Analysis Project | 2022–2024

27	0.30	13.4%
EU Countries Analyzed	Pearson Correlation (Weak)	Avg Negative Perception

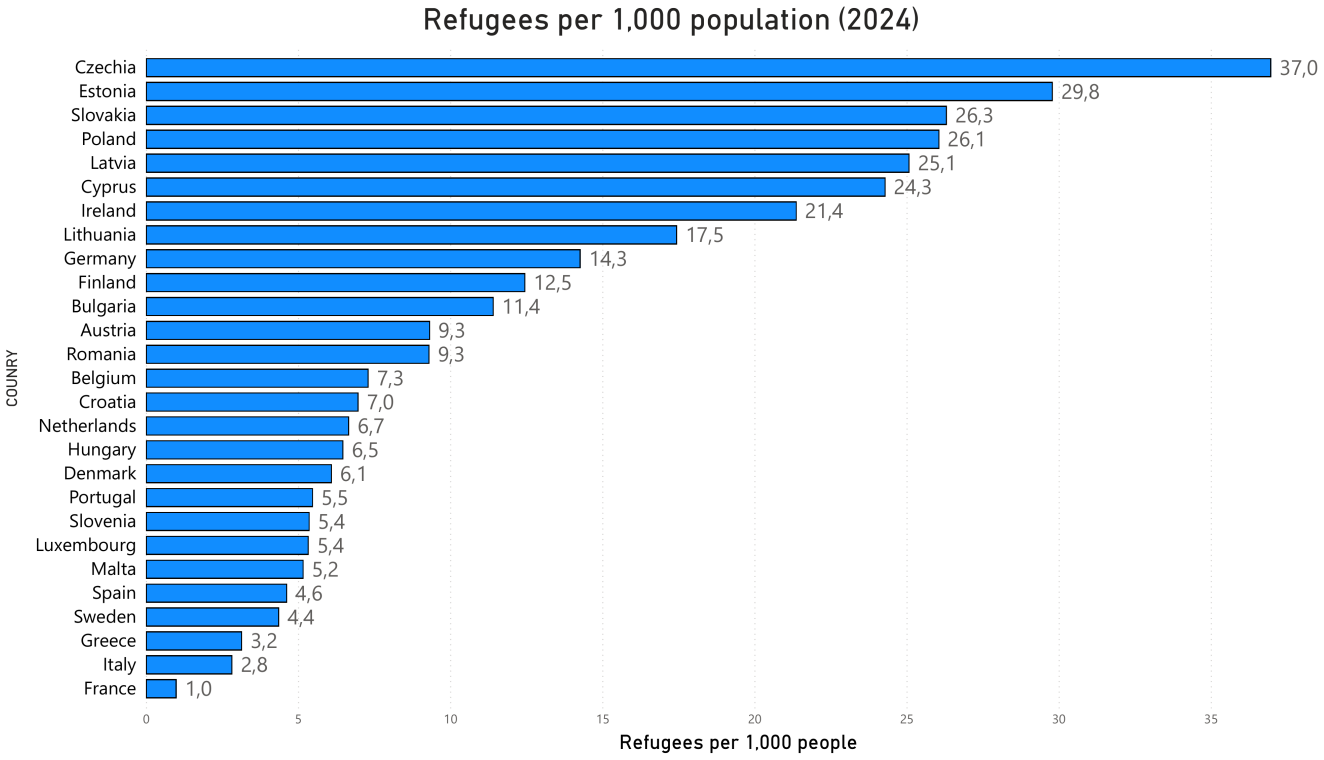
Research Question: Do countries with more Ukrainian refugees actually have worse economies, or is the negative perception just not backed by data?

Hypothesis: Negative attitudes do NOT correlate with economic deterioration or refugee numbers.

Result: Confirmed. Weak correlation (r=0.30) — refugee numbers don't predict negative perception.

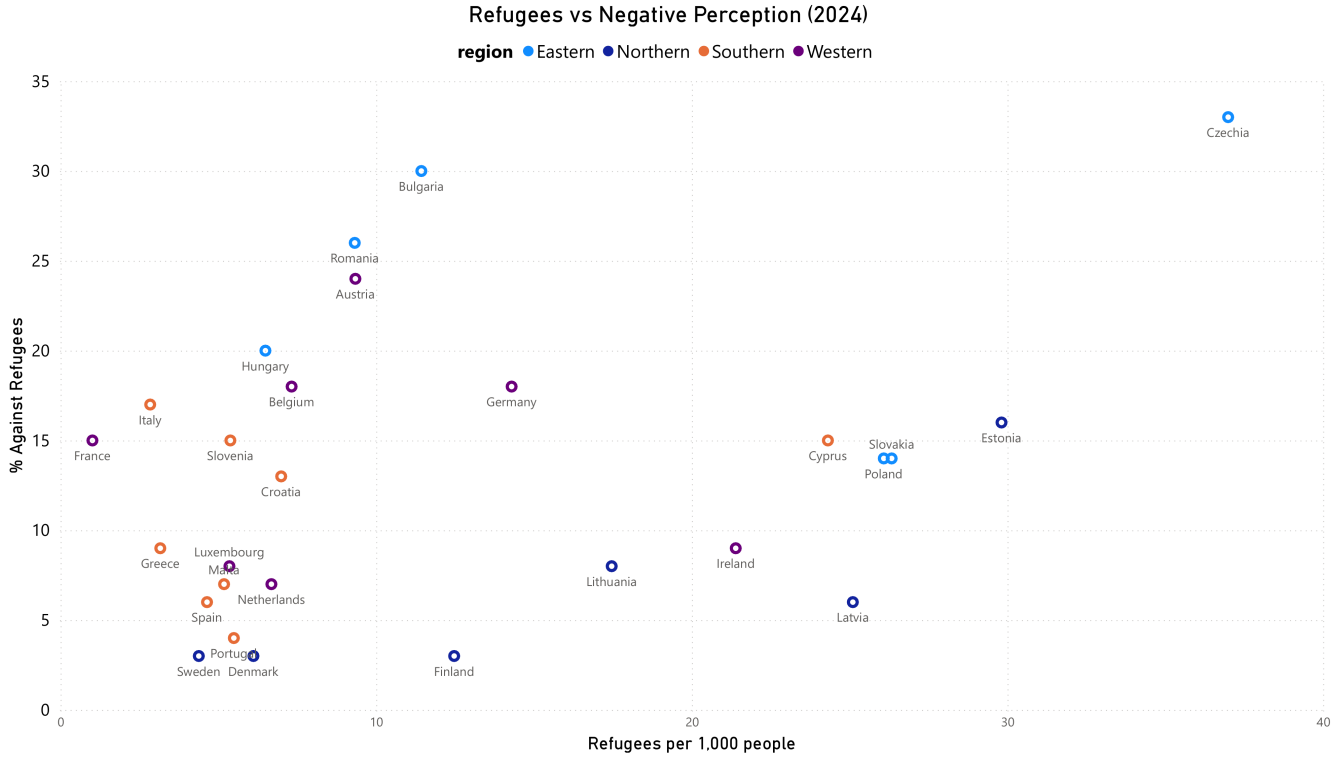
PostgreSQL Power BI Excel UNHCR / Eurobarometer / Eurostat

Finding 1: Refugee Distribution by Country



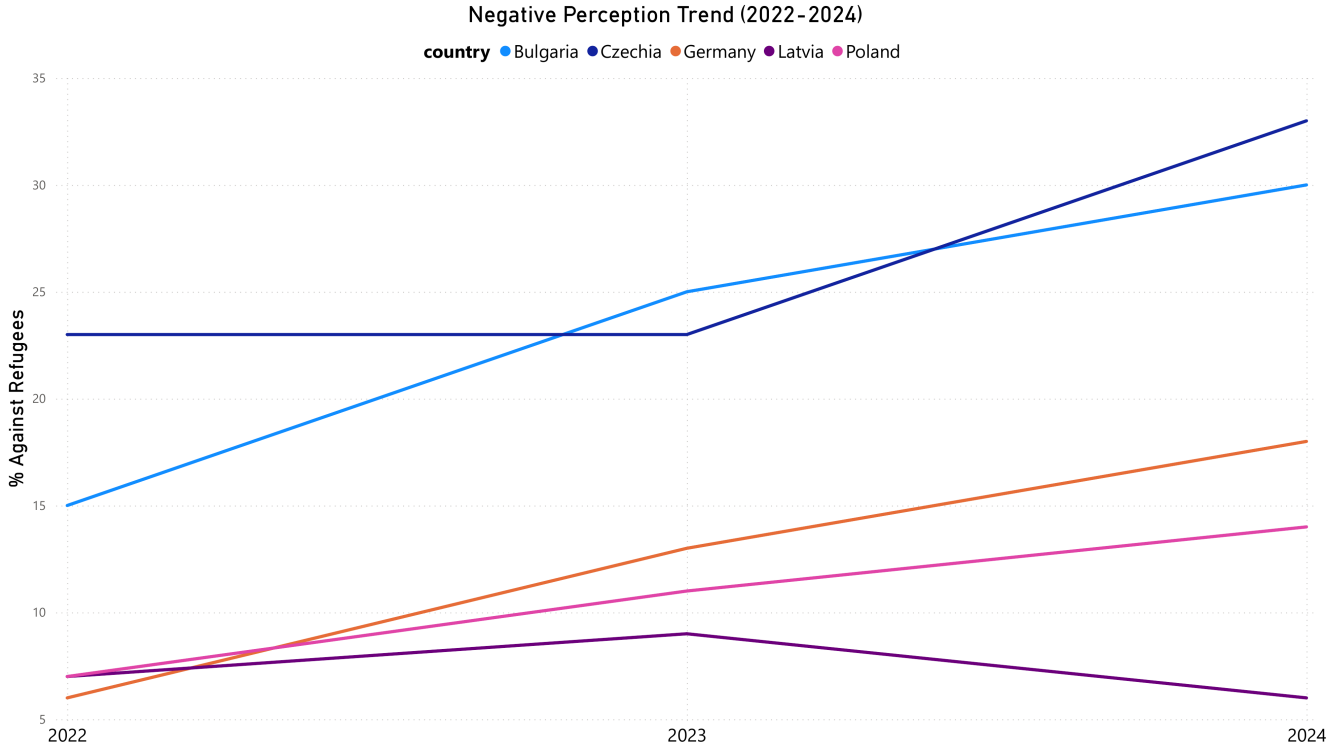
Key Observations: Eastern neighbors bear the highest burden: Czechia (37.0), Estonia (29.8), Slovakia (26.3), Poland (26.1). Germany hosts 1.2M in absolute terms but only 14.3 per 1,000. Geographic proximity matters most.

Finding 2: Refugees vs Negative Perception



Main Finding: Weak correlation (r=0.30). High refugees + Low negativity: Latvia (25→6%), Poland (26→14%). Low refugees + High negativity: Bulgaria (11→30%), Romania (9→26%).

Finding 3: Perception Trends (2022-2024)



5 Countries Selected: Czechia (highest negativity + refugees), Bulgaria (sharp growth), Poland (high refugees, low negativity), Germany (reference), Latvia (declining negativity despite high refugees).

Finding 4: Economic Reality Check

EU Countries Analyzed

27

Avg Refugees per 1,000 (2024)

12,42

Avg Negative Perception % (2024)

13,37

Pearson Correlation: 0.30 (weak)

Refugee numbers do not strongly predict negative perception

Refugee Level	Avg Inflation	Avg GDP Growth	Countries
Low (<10/1000)	2.9%	+1.8%	16
Medium (10-20)	1.8%	+1.6%	4
High (20+/1000)	2.6%	+1.8%	7

Result: High-refugee countries actually have lower inflation (2.6%) than low-refugee ones (2.9%). GDP growth is the same. The 'refugees hurt the economy' narrative is not supported by this data.

Conclusions

The hypothesis holds.

The correlation between refugee numbers and negative perception is weak (r=0.30). Having more refugees in a country doesn't mean people there will be more negative about it.

The economy is not the issue.

Countries hosting the most refugees show the same or better economic indicators than those hosting fewer. The idea that refugees hurt the economy is not supported by this data.

Something else drives negative perception.

Political climate, media coverage, historical attitudes, and government messaging seem to matter more than the actual number of refugees. Bulgaria and Romania have few refugees but high negativity.

Proximity to Ukraine helps.

Countries closest to Ukraine (Poland, Latvia, Lithuania) tend to be more accepting, possibly because the conflict feels more real and personal there.

Limitations

This is correlation, not causation. I can show patterns but can't prove what causes what.

Only 3 years of data. A longer period would make the analysis more reliable.

Eurobarometer surveys measure what people say, not necessarily what they do.

Country-level data hides a lot of variation within regions and demographics.

GDP and inflation depend on many factors beyond refugee presence.

What could be improved

Add regional data within countries (NUTS-2 level) for a more detailed picture.

Break down by demographics: age, education, urban vs rural.

Extend the time series as new Eurobarometer surveys come out.

Run a proper regression with control variables.

Analyze media coverage to test whether it drives perception.

Methodology & Data Sources

Table	Records	Key Fields
countries	27	country_name, iso_code, region, population
refugees	81	year, country, refugee_count, refugees_per_1000
perception	81	year, country, disagree_pct
economic_indicators	162	year, country, gdp_growth_pct, inflation_rate

SQL Queries: 1) Refugees per capita 2) Negative perception 3) Main JOIN 4) High negativity + GDP growth 5) Economic by refugee level 6) Trend by year 7) Pearson correlation

Data Preparation: Tables were merged using Power Query (JOIN on country + year) to create a single flat table for accurate scatter plot visualization in Power BI.

Perception Metric: Eurobarometer EB97, EB99, STD101. Question: 'Welcoming in the EU people fleeing the war'. Metric: % 'Disagree' + 'Totally disagree'.

Dataset	Source	URL
Refugees	UNHCR	data.unhcr.org
Perception	Eurobarometer	europa.eu/eurobarometer
GDP & Inflation	Eurostat	ec.europa.eu/eurostat

Project Links:

GitHub: https://github.com/likhotskyi/refugee_perception_analysis
LinkedIn: https://www.linkedin.com/in/vasyl-likhotskyi-89b1a83b5